

HOW TO HANDLE THE TRANSITION

The best way for a wealth creator to successfully transfer the reins of power is to oversee that transition himself while he still has his wits about him. That means making the transition sooner rather than later. For the wealth creator, it means a transition from being the “commander-in-chief” of the family to an elder.

The role of the elder is a critical one for a successful multigenerational family. Elders serve as a sort of judicial branch of the family. Elders can also help resolve family disputes and make sure the family is following its stated values and goals.

Each elder will have his preferences about where he wants to be and what he wants to do. It’s a personal matter. The important thing is to make sure you don’t sideline him and that you show the respect for the position as an elder and encourage him to perform that role.

If you set things up right, the wealth creator will be happy to take on the role of elder at the right time. Beyond settling disputes, elders should transmit the family culture from generation to generation by telling the family stories and being the family history. The elders also help with the spiritual development of the family, religious or otherwise. They also help preserve family ethics.

FAMILY COUNCIL LEADERSHIP

In each generation, there needs to be a leader of the council, someone who takes a little more responsibility for making sure things stay on track.

Centuries ago, the Irish clans had a system called *tanistry*, wherein a successor to the chief was chosen from a group of eligible males who were related, via the male line, within four generations of the chief. This group of eligibles was called the *roydamna* (meaning, “those of kingly material”).